

Languages, Scripts, Literature and Manuscripts

One factual spine: classification -> scripts -> corpora -> status ledgers -> manuscripts -> dated evidence

CLASSIFICATION FIREWALL

- family != script != register != constitutional status != cultural recognition
- Start every answer by separating the axis before adding examples.

FAMILY + REGISTER MAP

- Indo-Aryan / Dravidian / Austroasiatic / Tibeto-Burman
- Sanskrit + Pali + Prakrits + Apabhramsha + vernacular publics
- Rule: coexistence and layered transition, not neat replacement.

SCRIPT / EPIGRAPHY RAIL

- Harappan undeciphered -> Ashoka's Prakrit-Brahmi / Kharoshthi / Greek-Aramaic
- Prinsep 1837 matters for decipherment; scripts do not equal families.
- Grantha / Sharada / Gurmukhi / Modi / Ol Chiki / Nandinagari = regional script bank.

MANUSCRIPTS + CORPORA

- palm leaf / birch bark / colophon / commentary / critical edition
- Vedic / epic / Buddhist / Jain / Sangam / classical Sanskrit corpora
- Composition date != surviving manuscript date != edition date.

PALLAVA + MEDIEVAL PUBLICS

- Pallava route: Kanchipuram + Dandin + bilingual Tamil-Sanskrit inscriptions + Grantha
- Persian interaction + Urdu + Hindi + Bhakti-Sufi expansion widen literary publics.

CURRENT STATUS LEDGER

- Article 343 = official language of the Union
- Eighth Schedule = 22 | Classical languages = 11 | Sahitya Akademi working field = 24

REVISED CLASSICAL-LANGUAGE CRITERIA (PIB PRID 2061660)

- 1. high antiquity of early texts / recorded history over 1,500-2,000 years
- 2. body of ancient literature/texts treated as heritage by generations of speakers
- 3. knowledge texts, especially prose in addition to poetry, plus epigraphical / inscriptional evidence
- 4. classical language/literature may be distinct from current form or discontinuous with later forms/offshoots
- Historical caution: do NOT use the older 'original and not borrowed' formula as the current criterion set.

DOCUMENTARY HERITAGE + SAFEGUARDING

- Use individually verified UNESCO entries; do not assume an unverified current total.
- Bakhshali / place value = dated evidence, not slogan history.
- Gyan Bharatam survey (16 Mar 2026): identify -> verify -> metadata -> conserve / digitise.